

Interview Prep Guide

Product Manager Power Day

Congratulations on your upcoming interview day with Capital One!

We have been impressed with your background so far and can't wait to meet you. At Capital One, we value well-rounded associates and our selection process has been built to reflect the unique skill sets we look for on our Product teams. Our Product Managers engage in critically important work-creating the products that positively impact customers' lives daily. Successful Product Managers at Capital One are creative, analytical, and customer focused; your time with us will challenge you on those dimensions.

As you prepare for your interviews, please use this guide as a point of reference to answer any questions you may have. Your interview day will consist of four assessments, with a behavioral interview question at the beginning of one of the Product cases and at the Product Skills Interview. The interview line-up includes: 2 Product cases, a Product Skills Interview, and a Product Discovery case.

Not sure what those interviews look like? Keep reading!



Virtual interview

Virtual interviews allow our interviewers to get to know you using video and web-conferencing services, without having to be physically in the same room as you. Our virtual interviewing system, Zoom, offers various functions that help support our interviews including:

- **Whiteboard:** Draw and type freely to show work when problem solving with your interviewer
- **Screenshare:** Allows users to share applications from their desktop or website (i.e. product design, spreadsheet, chart, etc.)
- **Chat:** Ability to communicate real-time with your interviewer on your desktop

For best results

- Zoom supports all major browsers
- It is recommended to turn device on at least 1 hour prior to interview
- You will need a webcam and a reliable internet connection.
- Ensure your computer is fully charged or you have a charger plugged in prior to the Live Video Interview.
- Take time to read through this document and the email provided to you by your recruiter
- Have a pen, paper, & a calculator (as needed) ready
- If you experience issues with the audio, dial in from a cell phone or landline
- Please note: Zoom does not have annotation capabilities on the web connection. We recommend downloading the free Zoom client from <https://zoom.us>. Please use the PC/Mac/Mobile clients

Virtual interview overview

1. Launch Zoom
2. We recommend you test your microphone & audio using a "test" meeting invite
 - a. Follow prompts to test speakers (you will hear a ringtone)
 - b. Follow prompts to test your microphone (speak, pause, & hear your replay)
3. Once you've tested your audio, select "Join Meeting" in the Zoom application
4. Enter the Meeting ID, which can be found in your email invitation
5. You will be prompted to choose your interview's video and audio selections
6. Once you make your selections, you will be connected with your interviewer
7. We ask that you don't come to the interview with notes or utilize any outside resources



Whether you're participating in an in-person or virtual interview our goal is the same—to get know you better. Prepare for your interviews as you would for an in-person and make sure you arrive early to your virtual "room". Your interview guide will help you through the process like any other interview.

Don't Forget that you will be on camera and that will be a two-way conversation between you and your interviewer. Some additional tips and tricks to make sure you make a good impression include:



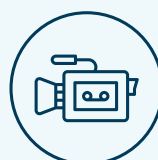
Dress to impress: wear the same attire you would for an in-person interview.



Minimize distractions: be sure you are in a location with minimal background noise and set your phone on silent.



Do not disturb: close all other computer programs that may cause disruptions.



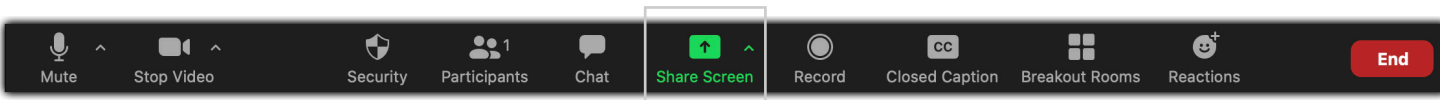
Ready for your close-up: be aware of your surroundings and lighting. Sit in front of a neutral background that avoids potential distractions.

How to use the whiteboard feature

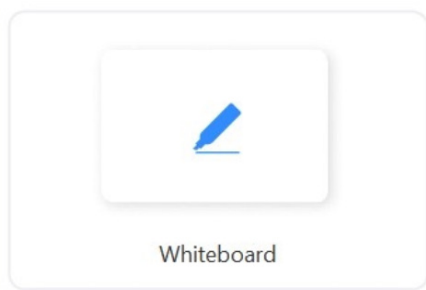
The interactive whiteboard allows candidates and interviewers to actively engage and receive instant feedback. With different annotation features, you will be able to draw, write text, and share screens.

Steps to leverage the whiteboard feature

1. Click the **Share Screen** button located in your meeting tool-bar



2. Click **Whiteboard**

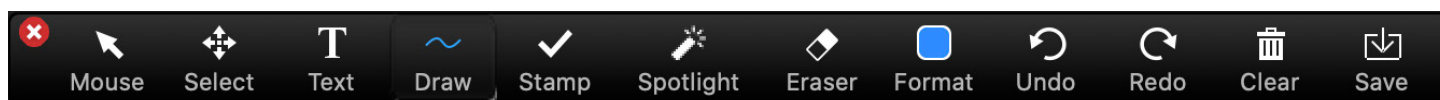


3. Click **Share**

4. The **annotation tools** will appear automatically, but you can press the Whiteboard option in the meeting controls to show and hide them.

Annotation tools

- **Mouse:** Deactivate annotation control and switch back to your mouse pointer.
- **Select:** Select, move, or resize your annotations.
- **Text:** Insert text.
- **Draw:** Insert lines, arrows, and shapes.
- **Stamp:** Insert predefined icons like a check mark or star.
- **Spotlight/Arrow:** Turn your cursor into a spotlight or arrow.
- **Eraser:** Click and drag to erase parts of your annotation.
- **Format:** Change the formatting options of the annotation tools.
- **Undo:** Undo your latest annotation.
- **Redo:** Redo your latest annotation that you undid.
- **Clear:** Delete all annotations.



5. **Tips & Tricks** when using the Whiteboard feature:

- Typically, your interviewer will initiate all Whiteboard sessions. When you're ready to annotate, you will need to request access by navigating to the menu bar, selecting "View Options," and "Request Remote Control"
- Once the interviewer grants you access, you will both be able to simultaneously annotate
- When selecting the "Text" annotation, your text will not appear on the other participant's screen unless you hit "Enter" using your keyboard

6. Use the **page controls** in the bottom-right corner of the whiteboard to create new pages and switch between pages.

Note: Only the participant or host that started sharing the whiteboard has access to create and switch pages.

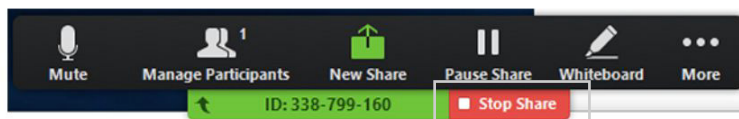


How to use the whiteboard feature (continued)

7. Click **More** in the meeting controls for these annotation options:

- Allow/Disable participants annotation: Allow or prevent the participants from annotating on your shared screen.
- Show/Hide Names of Annotators: Show or hide the participants' name when they are annotating. If set to show, the participant's name will briefly display beside their annotation.

8. When you are done, click **Stop Share**



Your interview

What to expect

The order of your interviews and breaks may vary, so don't be alarmed if you start your day off with a break, followed by four interviews.

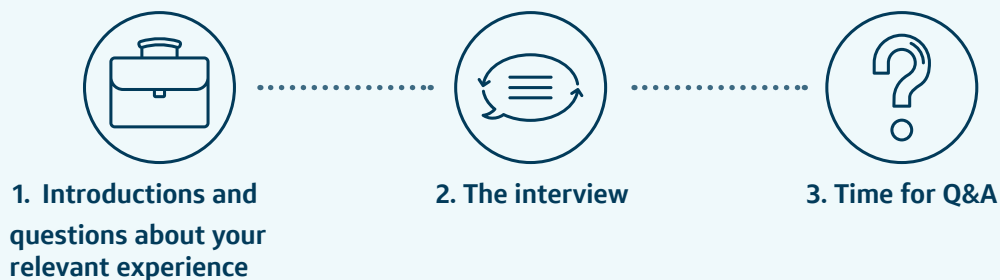
All of our interviews are conducted one-on-one, but in some cases you may have two associates in your interview. However, only one of the associates will be asking you questions. The other is simply observing as a training exercise.

During any breaks you may have, feel free to turn off your video, check your email, study, or make a phone call. We encourage you to spend your break time doing whatever makes you comfortable.

Interviews are scheduled in 60-minute blocks, but may not last the full time. You're welcome to use any remaining time to ask your interviewers questions. We expect you to come prepared with a few, well thought-out questions for each interviewer, as this is a good way to show that you are engaged and interested in Capital One, as well as the position.

Lastly, we may ask to chat with you a bit more for some additional information before we make a hiring decision. If we ask you to stay for an additional conversation, don't be alarmed. It is not necessarily good or bad; we just want to make sure we make the most informed hiring decision possible.

Your interviews will consist of 2 Product Cases, one Product Skills Interview, and a Product Discovery case. Typically, these interviews will be broken up into **three different sections**:



Product Case

What they are

The Product Case is an interactive interview where you're tasked with solving a real-life business problem. Your caser will work through a business question with you, while evaluating your strategic thinking, analytical skills, and quantitative abilities as you solve for solutions.

Why they're included

As a Product Manager at Capital One, you need to be able to understand data, communicate effectively with both business leaders and technical teams, and leverage data to make the best decisions for our customers. These cases present a hypothetical business situation where you would be required to navigate through the business challenges and leverage data and judgment to guide your decisions.

Product Skills Interview

What it is

The Product Skills Interview is an interactive interview where you will discuss how you have practiced and honed your leadership, business, innovation, and technical skills. Rather than discuss the broad array of your experiences and accomplishments, we will use this time to explore your leadership of one significant project.

Why it's included

As a Product Manager at Capital One, you will manage the delivery of complex projects that have a significant impact on the business and our customers. Product Managers assume a wide variety of responsibility, and success in the role often means drawing on relevant past experience.

Product Discovery Case

What it is

At its core, the Product Discovery case is a collaborative working session. During the Product Discovery case, you'll be given a design case and will ideate with a Capital One associate on potential solutions.

Why it's included

We want to see what exciting new products you can come up with after an hour of open collaboration with current Capital One Designers and Product Managers. We're looking for candidates who are passionate about ideas, creativity, and building the best products of tomorrow. Sound like you? You can get started by turning to the instructions on the next page.

The Case Interview

Welcome to your case interviews!

Case interviews are interactive interviews where you're tasked with solving a real-life business problem, like the ones that Capital One associates tackle every day. Your caser will work through a broad business question with you, broken down into multiple pieces, until you arrive at a solution together.

What we're looking for

Remember, a case interview is not a mathematics exam- we want to evaluate your skillset holistically. It's not just about 'solving for the right number'- it's more about how you problem solve generally. We're looking for candidates who exhibit strong communication skills, conceptual thinking, analytical abilities, strategic business sense, and a human-centered product mindset. The questions that compose both cases will give you the chance to demonstrate those skills and more.

How do the cases compare?

The Product Case and Product Discovery case have a similar set-up and give us similar reads, so studying these case prep materials will help you with both interviews. The differences and similarities are outlined below.

Product Cases

- Content focuses on a strategic business question, which could be based upon a variety of business topics.

Both

- Involve solving a real-life business problem with your interviewer
- Interactive in nature
- Evaluate your analytical skills, conceptual problem solving skills, and communication skills

Product Discovery Case

- Content focuses on creative problem solving
- Assesses ability to frame problem spaces and ideate solutions

Ready to practice?

Now that you've heard more about case interviews, what exactly do we mean by 'analytical'? As a data-driven organization, we want to make sure you have a certain level of fluency with numerical reasoning and problem solving. While brushing up on your math skills, some great places to start are practicing break-even equations and weighted averages.

Break-even example

If I need to make \$40,000 this year and I make \$20 per pair of shoes, how many pairs of shoes do I need to sell?
 $40,000 = 20x$, $x = 2,000$ pairs of shoes

Weighted average example

A group of 15 students took the SAT. 8 of them had an average score of 660, and the other students had an average score of 720. What is the average score of the whole group? $((8 \times 660) + (7 \times 720)) / 15 = 688$

You can see where those analytical skills come into play during a real case. **A sample Capital One case is included below.** We highly recommend having a friend or family member give you this case out loud, so you can get a better feel for the case interview interaction model.

Time to show your stuff!

Sample Case

Background case

- You are a manager at a company that markets various products and services and that is looking to diversify.
- You receive some information that indicates magazine publishing may be interesting.
- You are considering developing a new magazine but are not sure how profitable it might be.

What are some of the issues you must consider when evaluating the business?

Things to consider

- Defining the target market
- Competition (# of competitors, fragmentation, brand name)
- Build off core competencies
- Barriers to entry
- Business cycle stage
- Method of measuring viability
- Opportunity cost

The next step is to understand the economics of the business. What are the profit drivers in the magazine publishing business?

Main profit drivers of the publishing business include

Sources of Revenue

- Subscriptions
- Newsstand sales
- Advertising
- Customer lists
- Internet

Costs

- Printing
- Distribution
- Content development
- Marketing / promotions

Sample case (continued)**Through some initial research, you have been able to determine the following:**

- You can charge \$25 for an annual subscription of 50 issues
- Let's ignore newsstand sales for now
- You can generate \$1 in advertising revenue per issue for each subscription
- Printing and distribution costs are \$1 per copy per issue
- Content development costs run \$1 million per year
- Let's ignore marketing expenses for now

How much profit will you generate a year from one incremental subscription?

- Subscription revenue per year = \$25
- Advertising revenue per year = \$50
(\$1/issue X 50 issues)
- Yearly production and distribution costs = \$50
(\$1 /issue X 50 issues)
- Profit from one incremental subscription = \$25
(\$25 + \$50 - \$50)

How many subscriptions do we need to sell to break even?

- Profit (contribution margin) = \$25 per subscription
- Magazine content development = \$1 million per year
- Breakeven = \$1 million/\$25 = 40,000 subscriptions

What about marketing costs?

- Your company has expertise in direct mail solicitation so you decide to use that marketing method.
- Each piece of mail costs \$0.50
- You are able to achieve a 2% response rate

How much does it cost you to sign up a subscriber?

- Cost per subscriber calculation
- Cost of mailing / response rate = cost to sign up one subscriber
- $\$0.50 / 2\% = \25 per subscriber
- Another way to calculate cost per subscriber:
 - Assume you mail offer to 100 people
 - Costs = \$50 (\$0.50 x 100 people)
 - Responders = 2 (2% of 100)
 - Cost per responder = \$25 (\$50 / 2)

How will this affect your breakeven calculation?

- New breakeven calculation
- Old contribution margin - Marketing costs = New contribution margin
- New contribution margin = \$25 - \$25 = \$0
- Ouch!

What can we do to make this venture better?

- Raise subscription prices
- Increase response rate
- Raise advertising rates
- Make each response matter more; consider renewals and multi-year subscriptions
- Reduce production costs

Product Skills Interview

Welcome to the product skills interview! We're excited to learn more about your background and interest in product management. In advance of this interview, it's important to look back on your personal and academic experiences and choose one major product to discuss in depth.

What we're looking for

We'll look at this project as if it were a product that you managed. We'll ask you about your "customer," we'll talk about the financial implications, the team and stakeholders, and we will ask about the components that needed to come together to make it a success. In short, we are building the analogy of your project to product management.

As you consider the project for discussion, keep these guidelines in mind

- Failure is the most likely outcome of the most ambitious undertakings. It's okay if your project wasn't a resounding success. What did you learn?
- Product Management at Capital One is focused on the delivery of software - an inherently complex undertaking. You'll be expected to work with designers and engineers to deliver value to the customer, so if your project was technical, that's relevant! If not, that's fine too, but be prepared to explain all the intricacies of the moving parts.
- Please don't prepare any documents in advance -- no presentations, no videos, no handouts. The best way to prepare for this interview is to know which project you want to discuss and to have it fresh in your mind. The more recent it is, the easier it will be to remember the details. If you choose to discuss something further back in time, it's a good idea to spend some time recalling the details.

Product Discovery Case

Welcome to the Product Discovery case

The Product Discovery case interview is a collaborative work session where you're tasked with solving a real-life design problem. You will work with your interviewer to explore problems spaces, brainstorm potential solution and talk through how you would take it to market. Please read the interview outline to get a sense of how the session will run. **We're excited to get to work!**

What we're looking for

The Product Discovery case is meant to be fun and allow you to work through creative problem solving. This case will give you the chance to demonstrate your ability to identify key user problems and ideate solutions with creativity and teamwork. We are looking for candidates who exhibit strong curiosity for problem solving, communication skills, human-centered product mindset and basic familiarity with technology.

Part 1

Explore & storyboarding

In the first section, you will be given a design case study to read through. Once the exploration of the design case is complete, you will be working together with your interviewer to identify any problems discovered from case reading.

Part 2

Ideation

After exploring the problem spaces, the real fun begins! You will be spending time leading an ideation session and collaborating with your interviewers to come up with product ideas that could solve one of the problems you found.

Note: Make sure that you take the time to explain your thought process as your interviewers will know nothing about the problem space. They'll rely on your guidance to educate them on whatever problem space you choose so that they can effectively ideate with you on a solution.

Part 3

Storyboarding

Once the ideation section is complete, you will work with your interviewer to take your solution one step further by drafting a storyboard. You will be using this visual storyboard to help explain your solution and discuss further how this idea could become closer to reality. Don't worry, drawing skills aren't necessary!

Have fun exploring, synthesizing, and ideating! **"We're looking forward to it" is an understatement.**

After your interview

Your recruiter will contact you within 3-5 business days after your interview to deliver results— **yes, that quick!** If results are expected any longer than our usual time-frame, your recruiter will reach out to let you know!

FAQs

What's the dress code for an interview at Capital One?

You are welcome to dress in whatever clothing makes you feel comfortable, but our associates will be dressed business casual or casual.

How many candidates will you be interviewing for the role?

While we do not predetermine how many candidates we interview for a position, there will likely be other candidates interviewing the same day as you. Be aware that we make hiring decisions solely based on your personal interview performance and not how you compare to other candidates.

How soon will I receive my interview results?

Your recruiter will contact you within 3-5 business days with a final hiring decision. Results may be delivered sooner than 3-5 business days and, if expected to take longer, we'll let you know.

Additional resources



[Life at Capital One](#)

We proudly bring together associates with diverse perspectives, backgrounds, and experiences in an environment where they can challenge the status quo and reimagine money to inspire life.

[YouTube case preparation](#)

We've created our very own YouTube Case Preparation video to help candidates prepare for our unique, analytically rigorous case interviews. This video will help give you a better idea of what you can expect during your case.